

Should *Nature* Streamline Its Final Submission Guidelines?

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Abstract

This study critically evaluates the final submission guidelines of *Nature* (2026), focusing on their potential to impose unnecessary administrative burdens on researchers. Jiang et al. (2019) found that 91.1% of scientists support streamlined formatting requirements and estimated that reformatting requirements cost the scientific community and funders \$1.1 billion annually. Specific requirements, including those concerning electronic image formats and extended data displays, may contribute to this burden without providing substantial additional scientific or editorial value. This study argues that *Nature* may reduce redundant requirements to improve efficiency and reduce costs. However, the analysis is limited to *Nature*'s final submission guidelines and may not be generalizable to its other publication policies or other journals.

Introduction

Scientific journals impose submission standards to promote consistency and ensure publication quality. However, extensive formatting requirements, particularly at the final submission stage, can create additional work without improving the scientific content of a manuscript. *Nature*'s Final Submission guidelines (2026) include detailed specifications for figures, electronic image formats, display items, and supplementary materials. While some of these requirements are essential to maintaining scientific rigor and publication quality, others appear to serve primarily stylistic or production-related purposes.

Jiang et al. (2019) found that 91.1% of researchers preferred streamlined formatting and estimated the annual cost of reformatting requirements at \$1.1 billion. This study therefore examines whether *Nature*'s final submission requirements may be simplified to reduce this burden without compromising scientific or publication standards.

Methodology

A qualitative assessment of *Nature*'s Final Submission guidelines (2026) was conducted, with particular attention to technical requirements concerning electronic image formats, display items, and extended data. These requirements were assessed according to their apparent purpose and the administrative burden they may impose on authors. The findings were contextualized using the evidence presented by Jiang et al. (2019). No primary data were collected; the analysis relies exclusively on publicly available submission guidelines and previously published evidence.

Results

The analysis indicates that certain *Nature* requirements, including specifications for electronic image formats and the presentation of display items, may create additional technical work for authors without substantially affecting the scientific evaluation of a manuscript. Although such requirements may facilitate the production process, their direct contribution to scientific rigor appears limited.

These findings are consistent with Jiang et al. (2019), who documented strong researcher support for streamlined formatting and identified substantial economic costs associated with reformatting requirements. The results suggest that *Nature* may distinguish more clearly between requirements that are necessary for scientific accuracy and those intended primarily to ensure stylistic or production consistency.

Discussion

Nature's technical standards should be retained when they contribute directly to scientific accuracy, accessibility, or publication quality. However, requirements that do not materially affect scientific assessment, particularly those intended primarily to ensure stylistic consistency, may be simplified, automated, or deferred until the production stage.

Such changes may reduce the administrative workload associated with manuscript preparation while preserving publication standards. This study does not estimate the precise time or financial savings that might result from such changes because it does not include new empirical data.

Conclusion

Nature may consider streamlining its Final Submission guidelines by removing or simplifying requirements that provide limited scientific or editorial value. Evidence from Jiang et al. (2019), together with the present analysis of *Nature*'s guidelines, indicates that unnecessary reformatting can impose substantial costs on researchers and funders. Simplifying these requirements may reduce administrative burdens while maintaining the quality and integrity of scientific publications.

References

- Jiang, Yan, Robert Lerrigo, Anika Ullah, Muthu Alagappan, Steven M. Asch, Steven N. Goodman, and Sidhartha R. Sinha. 2019. "The High Resource Impact of Reformatting Requirements for Scientific Papers." Edited by Lamberto Manzoli. *PLOS ONE* 14 (10): e0223976. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0223976>.
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